

The Artillery State

Cannon, Code, and the Return of the Consolidator

A Detailed Book Outline

Frontmatter

Working title

The Artillery State: Cannon, Code, and the Return of the Consolidator

Alternates auditioned in the introduction's footnote: *Not Modernity, But Tudor; The Longbow or the Cannon; After the Middle Ages, Again.*

The one-sentence thesis

The neomedieval condition described by Bull, Friedrichs, and Cerny is not a terminus but the mid-point of a repeatable historical arc; the specific mechanism that ended it once — the capital-intensification of decisive force, coupled to the fiscal-administrative and legibility infrastructure required to sustain it — is operating again now, and it predicts a Tudor-style re-consolidation, executed inside civilizational blocs rather than across them.

The one-paragraph thesis

The literature on the "new Middle Ages" has been correct about the diagnosis and wrong about the prognosis. Bull, Friedrichs, Cerny, Kobrin, McFate, Williams, Zielonka, Wæver, Rengger, and Slaughter between them built a compelling account of the dispersal phase: overlapping sovereignties, private force, transnational lords, jurisdictional grey zones, the durable disorder that follows the unbundling of state functions. What they never wrote — because the FAANG era arrived after the concept was set — was the re-consolidation. The medieval original had one: between roughly 1450 and 1530, the Bureau brothers' siege train, the *compagnies d'ordonnance*, the *taille*, the Tudor Chamber, Isabella's *hermandades*, the Ottoman *devşirme*, and the printing press together produced the first fiscal-military states in Europe since Rome. The mechanism was not English and it was not accidental; it happened simultaneously across the continent because gunpowder artillery changed the economics of sovereignty, and only rulers who could afford artillery trains, standing companies, permanent taxation, and legible populations could operate at the new scale. This book argues that a functionally identical mechanism is running now — the compute-foundry-satellite-munitions-at-scale stack, plus the identity-attestation-financial-rails legibility stack — and that it will produce Tudor-style consolidators inside each of three or four civilizational blocs. The neomedieval literature described the dispersal; this book describes the return swing.

Argument architecture

The book runs three claims in sequence:

1. **Diagnostic (Part I).** The neomedieval frame is correct as a description of the last three decades. Sovereignty has been unbundled; universal claims have re-emerged in the form of transnational platforms; private force has returned to the top table; jurisdiction has become plural and contested. This part accepts the Friedrichs–Cerny–Kobrin diagnosis and extends it, but corrects two errors in the literature: the treatment of platforms as market actors rather than as institutional universalisms with their own canon law, and the assumption that dispersal is stable rather than transitional.
2. **Mechanistic (Part II).** The medieval dispersal ended for identifiable, causally-operative reasons. Between 1440 and 1500 the price of decisive violence changed. Walls stopped working because artillery worked. Standing companies replaced retinues because gunpowder infantry required paid drill. Permanent taxation replaced feudal aid because standing companies could not be raised by summons. The consolidation was a response to a technological shock, and its geography followed the shock: Charles VII's France, Henry VII's England, Ferdinand and Isabella's Spain, Mehmed's Ottomans, and (later, differently) the Habsburgs all executed variants of the same move. Part II establishes this as a mechanism rather than an analogy.
3. **Predictive (Part III).** The mechanism is operating again. The full military stack — orbital ISR constellations, hyperscale compute, leading-node foundries, munitions industrial base, hypersonic and directed-energy R&D — is more capital-concentrated than gunpowder ever was, and only three or four polities can hold it. The parallel legibility stack — digital identity, payment rails, satellite economic monitoring, foundation-model-mediated administration — creates the first infrastructure since print capable of making a population legible at continental scale. The Tudor return is therefore predicted, but not everywhere: it will consolidate *inside* civilizational blocs (a US-led maritime bloc, a Chinese continental bloc, a European regulatory bloc, and possibly an Indian bloc), producing what looks superficially like a return to great-power politics but is structurally a set of Tudor settlements running in parallel. The interstitial space between blocs will remain neomedieval — durable disorder as a permanent feature of the gaps, not the whole system.

Positioning against the existing literature

The book sits deliberately downstream of six texts and against one:

- **Downstream of Bull** (*Anarchical Society*, 1977, ch. 10): accepts the "new mediaevalism" framing as a serious hypothesis and takes Bull's own doubts seriously enough to answer them.
- **Downstream of Friedrichs** (2001 EJIR; 2007 book chapter): adopts the Church/Empire duality as the analytical frame but institutionalizes it — the universalisms have names, addresses, and balance sheets now.
- **Downstream of Cerny** (1998; 2005): uses the six-characteristics checklist as the diagnostic instrument in Part I and the "durable disorder" concept as the description of the interstitial spaces in Part III.

- **Downstream of Kobrin** (1998/1999): completes the argument Kobrin sketched — treats the digital economy's dissolution of territorial jurisdiction as the mechanism that produced the platform universalisms, and then asks what the states did about it.
- **Downstream of McFate** (2011 thesis; 2014): accepts the return of the market for force as evidence of dispersal, and asks the question McFate does not — how does a Tudor state re-domesticate the mercenary market, and is the US already doing so?
- **Downstream of Zielonka** (2006) and Wæver: treats the EU as the most advanced case of neomedieval polity and reads its regulatory turn (DMA, DSA, AI Act) as the beginning of its Tudor phase.
- **Against Holsinger** (2007) — but engaging seriously. Holsinger is right that neomedievalism has been used sloppily and instrumentally. The book's defense is that it is not offering an analogy but identifying a mechanism, and the mechanism is falsifiable. If the military and legibility stacks decentralize rather than concentrate, the thesis fails.

The book also stakes out ground against three implicit orthodoxies:

- Against the "end of history" residue (Fukuyama and its descendants): the modern condition is not stable liberal democracy interrupted by anomalies; it is a transition phase between two different sovereign orders.
- Against the "great power competition" frame now dominant in Washington and Brussels strategy shops: the current moment is not a return to Westphalian great-power politics; it is a set of Tudor consolidations that will only *look* Westphalian from the outside.
- Against the **Silicon Valley optimist frame** (Slaughter's disaggregated sovereignty read as a feature, not a bug): the platform universalisms will be nationalized, absorbed, or broken. Slaughter's networked government is what the neomedieval interregnum looks like, not what comes after it.

Method note

The book is a work of comparative historical analysis, not a work of prediction in the forecasting-tournament sense. Its predictions are conditional: *if* the military and legibility stacks continue to concentrate at their current trajectory, *then* Tudor-style consolidations should be observable inside identifiable polities within one to three decades, and the book identifies the signatures to look for. Where medieval sources are cited, they are cited from the standard historiography (Strayer, Anderson, Contamine, Vale, Parker, Elton, Elliott, Vaughan, Gunn, Ullmann). Where contemporary claims are made, they are cited from primary documents (regulatory instruments, industrial-policy legislation, procurement filings, platform terms of service, court judgments) supplemented by the neomedievalism literature summarized above.

Introduction: The Return Swing

Opening (approx. 4,000 words)

Open on Castillon, 17 July 1453. John Talbot, Earl of Shrewsbury, the last great English captain of the Hundred Years' War, charges the French artillery position on horseback and is killed by a cannon ball that also kills his horse. Around him, three hundred guns crewed by the Bureau brothers' *artilleurs* — a specialized, salaried, technical service that did not exist in any European army fifty years earlier — dismantle the English force. Within four months the English will be expelled from Gascony after three hundred years. Within five years, Normandy — retaken in a fourteen-month campaign built around the same siege train — will be French forever. The Hundred Years' War does not end at Castillon because the French finally out-fight the English; it ends because the French have built something the English do not have: a state that can pay for artillery.

Cut to the present. The scene is deliberately underdetermined — a semiconductor fab in Hsinchu, or a data center campus in Northern Virginia, or a launch site in Boca Chica, or a shipyard in Jiangnan. The claim being made is the same claim Castillon makes: the price of decisive capability has moved, and only certain polities can afford it.

Between those two scenes the book will argue three things.

First, that the world between them — the world of the last three decades — has been correctly described by a literature almost nobody outside international relations reads: the neomedievalism literature, running from Bull's cautious hypothesis in 1977 through Friedrichs's theoretical reconstruction in 2001, Cerny's "durable disorder" in 1998, Kobrin's prophecy about the digital economy in the same year, McFate's account of the return of private armies, Zielonka's reading of the EU as neomedieval empire, and the Copenhagen School's engagement with the frame in the 1990s. This literature diagnosed correctly. It saw the unbundling of sovereignty, the return of overlapping jurisdictions, the emergence of transnational universalisms, and the durability of the resulting disorder.

Second, that this literature made one large mistake, which was to treat the dispersal as terminal. The neomedieval condition is not an equilibrium. It is what the world looks like in the middle of a transition between two sovereign orders. The medieval original — the world of 1150 to 1450, with its Church and Empire, its condottieri and Hanseatic leagues, its plural jurisdictions and legal grey zones and durable disorder — was also mid-transition. What ended it was not modernity, an idea invented in retrospect. What ended it was cannon.

Third, that a functionally identical shock is running now, and it will produce a functionally identical response. Not modernity, again — but Tudor: personal-charismatic rule atop bureaucratic machinery, delivery-plus-spectacle legitimacy, transnational lords leashed rather than destroyed, canonical assertion of state authority over the platform universalisms, and — the critical piece — a re-nationalization of the functions the platforms currently perform. This will happen inside civilizational blocs, not across them. What looks from the outside like a return to great-power politics is structurally a set of parallel Tudor settlements.

The pendulum wager (approx. 2,500 words)

The introduction states the book's central bet in explicit terms. Bull, at the end of the *Anarchical Society* chapter, said the evidence for a new medievalism was insufficient to conclude that a new order was emerging. The book takes Bull's caution seriously and inverts it: the evidence is now sufficient, but the order being described is not the neomedieval one. The pendulum is real, and it is on its return swing.

The wager is made falsifiable. If, over the next fifteen years:

- The military stack decentralizes (cheap distributed autonomy defeats concentrated capital at the level of decisive engagement, not just tactical action)
- The legibility stack fragments (privacy-preserving, jurisdictionally-plural identity and payments systems become the default)
- Platform universalisms consolidate their independence from state authority rather than being nationalized or absorbed
- No identifiable Tudor moves are observable inside the major polities (fiscal absorption of platform surplus, canonical assertion over transnational subjects, absorption of private force, re-territorialization of critical infrastructure)

then the thesis fails and the neomedievalists were right that dispersal is stable. The book stakes itself on the opposite reading, and identifies the leading indicators throughout.

The three inoculations (approx. 3,500 words)

Three objections have to be disarmed in the introduction because they will otherwise haunt every subsequent chapter.

The declinism-cycle objection. Every generation announces the end of the state. Kaplan announced it in 1994 with "The Coming Anarchy." Bull hedged toward it in 1977. Slaughter announced its transformation in 2004. The book concedes the pattern and identifies why this cycle is different: not because the vibes are worse, but because the price of decisive capability has moved for identifiable, measurable, technology-specific reasons. This is the Roberts-Parker military-revolution move applied to the present. The book stakes itself on being wrong if the capital-intensity claim is wrong.

The fairyland objection. Rengger's 2000 essay ("The Dilemmas of Fairyland?") is the sharpest sympathetic critique of the neomedieval frame: are we analyzing the actual Middle Ages or a fantasy of them? Holsinger's 2007 pamphlet extends the critique to the political misuses of the analogy. The book's defense is architectural rather than rhetorical: it does not analogize between the Middle Ages and the present; it identifies a mechanism (weapon capital-intensity → fiscal state → consolidation) and asks whether it is operating in both periods. If the mechanism does not operate, the argument fails; if it does, the analogy is redundant.

The English-parochialism objection. The Tudor story, told alone, is an island story about a dynastic accident. The book's defense is that the Tudor settlement was one instance of a pan-European pattern — Louis XI in France, Ferdinand and Isabella in Spain, Mehmed II in the Ottoman lands, later Charles V in the Habsburg composite — and the shared cause was the

artillery revolution. The English case is used because it is the best-documented, but every chapter that leans on English evidence is paired with at least two continental cases. The comparative register is enforced throughout.

Roadmap (approx. 1,500 words)

Brief walk-through of the three parts and the twelve chapters. The reader is told that Part I will feel like an extended engagement with the neomedieval literature, Part II like a work of late-medieval military history, and Part III like a work of contemporary strategy — and that the point of the sequence is to demonstrate that these are three views of the same object.

Part I — The New Middle Ages

(Fragmentation, pan-European. The diagnostic phase. Four chapters, approx. 45,000 words.)

Chapter 1 — The Return of the Middle Ages

Purpose. Establish the neomedieval diagnosis at book length, treat Bull's own doubts as the honest starting point, and set the pan-European baseline against which everything that follows will be measured. This chapter accepts the terms of the existing literature and prepares the reader to see it, later, as incomplete.

Argument. Bull's five sub-trends — regional integration, state disintegration, private international violence, transnational organizations, the technological unification of the world — are all observably present now, at a level Bull himself did not live to see. Friedrichs's reconstruction of the concept as the duality between the state system and the transnational market economy is the correct analytical frame; Cerny's six characteristics are the correct diagnostic checklist. Cerny 2005, in the bundled Naval War College Review piece, applies the framework to the post-9/11 security landscape and provides the most operationally useful version of the checklist. The chapter runs the checklist against the present.

Structure.

1. Bull's hypothesis and Bull's caution. Close reading of the "A New Mediaevalism" section of *Anarchical Society* ch. 10 and the concluding chapter's skepticism. What Bull saw, what he doubted, and why the doubt was correct in 1977 and is not correct now.
2. The pan-European baseline circa 1200. Overlapping sovereignty as the continent's default; the papal monarchy as universal spiritual authority; the Empire as universal (contested) political authority; the local lord, the free city, the military order, the merchant league as the modal political units. This is the substrate against which the modern condition will be compared.
3. Friedrichs's reconstruction. Close reading of the 2001 EJIR article (or the 2007 book chapter version, which is the more polished statement of the same argument). The Church/Empire duality as the analytical engine, and its translation into the modern duality between the state system and the market. The chapter's argument at book length.

4. Cerny's six characteristics, applied. Multiple competing institutions; absence of exogenous territorializing pressures; uneven consolidation of new spaces, cleavages, and inequalities; fragmented loyalties and identities; entrenchment of property rights; legal grey zones and the black economy. Each characteristic gets a section of contemporary evidence. Cerny 2005 in the bundle is used as the war-college-tested version of the same checklist.
5. Slaughter's networked-government alternative. Slaughter's *A New World Order* is the optimist's read of the same phenomena — disaggregated sovereignty as networked governance rather than dispersal. The chapter treats Slaughter as important and wrong: the networks she identified were real, but they were the connective tissue of the dispersal phase, not the architecture of a new order.
6. The state as the anomaly. Setting up the book's frame: the Westphalian sovereign state is not the natural condition of European politics but a specific settlement produced by specific pressures, and if those pressures change, the settlement can change again.

Sources used.

- Bull, *Anarchical Society*, ch. 10 and concluding chapter (Cambridge Library access)
- Friedrichs 2001 EJIR article via Sage / Cambridge library resolver; the 2007 book chapter version as the polished substitute
- Cerny 2005 "Terrorism and the New Security Dilemma" (bundled, open-access NWCR)
- Cerny 1998 *Civil Wars* article via Taylor & Francis / Cambridge library resolver
- Slaughter, *A New World Order*, chs. 5 and 6 (bundled, author-hosted)
- Wight, *Systems of States*, "De Systematibus Civitatum" (Cambridge Library)
- Kaplan, "The Coming Anarchy" (bundled) — engaged critically, as the atmospheric predecessor
- Strayer, *On the Medieval Origins of the Modern State* (Cambridge Library) — for the c. 1200 baseline

Objection stress test. The medievalist's likely complaint: that the "overlapping sovereignty" description of c. 1200 flattens a period of enormous variation. The chapter concedes this and specifies that it is using the mid-thirteenth-century Rhineland and northern Italy as its baseline, both of which were unusually plural even by medieval standards, precisely because those are the periods and places the modern analogy most illuminates.

Chapter 2 — The New Church

Purpose. Fill the largest gap in the existing literature: the treatment of platforms as institutional universalisms with their own canon law, sanction regimes, doctrinal disputes, and jurisdictional claims — not as market actors and not as governance problems.

Argument. Kobrin in 1998 saw that a digital, networked economy dissolves the territorial basis of sovereignty. What Kobrin could not see, and what the literature never subsequently addressed, is that the void was filled by specific institutional actors with specific universalist claims. The Investiture Contest, the Avignon papacy, and the conciliarist movement are the correct historical templates for understanding the state-platform jurisdictional wars now

under way — not because history is repeating but because the underlying structural problem (two rival universal authorities claiming jurisdiction over the same subjects) is the same problem, and the medieval settlements to that problem are informative.

The chapter's central move. There is no single new Church. There are three rival churches — a US-led hyperscaler bloc, a Chinese state-platform hybrid, and an EU regulatory church — and the current condition is the analog not of the High Medieval papal monarchy but of the Great Schism. Three-body sovereignty is the modal condition. This framing is important because it sets up Part III's argument that consolidation will happen *inside* each bloc, not globally.

Structure.

1. Kobrin's prophecy re-read. Close reading of the bundled Wharton manuscript. What Kobrin got right (jurisdiction assumes geography; digital economies dissolve geography); what he could not see (which specific institutions would fill the void); what the literature failed to develop afterward.
2. The medieval templates. The Gregorian reform and the Investiture Contest as the founding argument about which universal authority invests officeholders with legitimacy. The Avignon papacy as the case of universal authority captured by a particular polity. Conciliarism as the intra-Church attempt to constrain universal authority through representative institution. Drawn from Ullmann's *Growth of Papal Government* (Cambridge Library) and the standard historiography.
3. The three modern churches, functionally described.
 - **The hyperscaler church** (Google, Meta, Apple, Amazon, Microsoft, and increasingly the frontier AI labs). Universal epistemic authority over discovery, memory, identity, and — with foundation models — cognition. Canon law visible in terms of service, community guidelines, and platform policy documents. Sanction regime: deplatforming as excommunication, demonetization as interdict, algorithmic demotion as penance.
 - **The Chinese state-platform church.** Universal authority *fused* with state authority rather than distinct from it. The post-2020 platform crackdown as an intra-church reform (Xi's Gregorian moment). Alibaba, Ant, Tencent, ByteDance as monastic orders under closer discipline. The claim to extraterritorial jurisdiction over Chinese-language digital life.
 - **The EU regulatory church.** Not a platform but a canonical authority asserting jurisdiction over the other two. GDPR, DMA, DSA, AI Act, and the Brussels effect as the doctrinal apparatus. The EU's peculiar position: no army, no compute, but real canonical authority over subjects on its territory and — through extraterritorial reach — beyond.
4. The Great Schism as the structural analog. Not the High Medieval papal monarchy but the fifteenth-century Schism, when three popes claimed universal authority simultaneously and each had territorial backers. The parallel is exact enough to be useful: three universalisms, mutually incompatible, each backed by a particular civilizational bloc.
5. The Investiture Contest, running now. Specific disputes examined at length: Apple vs. Meta on the App Store (who invests app publishers with legitimacy); the US-China chip war (who

invests AI development with permission); the EU's confrontation with US hyperscalers over data localization and gatekeeper designation; the frontier-AI labs' assertion of independent authority to release or withhold models. Each is a fifteenth-century argument in twenty-first-century clothes.

6. What the medieval settlement to this problem looked like. Preview of Part III's argument: the Investiture Contest was settled by the Concordat of Worms and never fully resolved; the more decisive settlement was Henry VIII's, which consisted of the state simply swallowing the Church's functions. The chapter foreshadows: the coming state will not break the platforms; it will nationalize them.

Sources used.

- Kobrin 1998/1999 (bundled)
- Ullmann, *The Growth of Papal Government in the Middle Ages* (Cambridge Library)
- Friedrichs 2001 / 2007 on the two universalisms
- Contemporary primary documents: the DMA and DSA texts; the EU AI Act; the Executive Orders on AI; Chinese platform regulations post-2020; App Store guidelines and their revision history; Section 230 case law
- Zielonka, *Europe as Empire* (Cambridge Library) — for the EU as canonical authority
- Slaughter chs. 5–6 (bundled) — as the alternative reading being rejected

Objection stress test. The platform apologist's likely complaint: that describing platforms as churches is a category error, since they are private firms operating under law. The chapter's answer: private firms operating at the scale and with the reach of the current platforms *become* institutional universalisms whether they intend to or not, in the same way the medieval Church was a set of institutions long before it was a coherent legal person. The question is not whether they are private firms but whether their functional role is that of a universalism, and the evidence — canonical rule-making, sanction regimes, extraterritorial reach, doctrinal disputes — is that it is.

Chapter 3 — Bastard Feudalism, Inc.

Purpose. Extend the neomedievalism-of-security thread beyond McFate's mercenary focus to the wider phenomenon of the contractor economy — the private provision of state functions across defense, intelligence, security, logistics, and adjacent domains — and show that the pattern is pan-European in its medieval original, not English.

Argument. The English institution of livery and maintenance — great magnates retaining armed followers through indentures rather than through the older feudal tenurial arrangements — has a French counterpart in the *écorcheurs* and the Burgundian ducal clientage, an Italian counterpart in the *condotta* system (properly treated in Chapter 4), and a German counterpart in the *Fehde* and *Landfrieden* traditions. The common structural feature across the West is that when the fiscal-military capacity of central authority weakens, the great subjects raise private forces to perform what were once state functions, financed through a mix of local rents, remittance from central authority, and self-provisioning through violence. The modern contractor economy — Blackwater/Academi, Wagner, DynCorp, G4S, Constellis, Palantir-as-

quasi-intelligence-service, the whole PMSC industry McFate anatomizes — is the same structural response to the same structural condition.

Structure.

1. The medieval original, done comparatively.
 - **England.** Livery and maintenance in the fifteenth century; the indenture as the characteristic legal instrument; McFarlane's account of the affinity as the operative political unit.
 - **France.** The *écorcheurs* — unemployed *routiers* and mercenary companies who preyed on the countryside during the truces of the Hundred Years' War; Charles VII's response through the *compagnies d'ordonnance* (Chapter 10's material, foreshadowed here).
 - **Burgundy.** The Valois dukes' clientage system and its distinctive fusion of chivalric ceremonial with paid retinue; Vaughan's account.
 - **Germany.** The *Fehde* and the *Landfrieden*, the imperial peace movements that tried and largely failed to contain private war within the Empire.
 - **Italy.** Held for Chapter 4; the *condotta* is the most developed form of the pattern.
2. The modern parallel. The rise of the PMSC industry from the 1990s onward. McFate's thesis, drawn from the bundled LSE dissertation: the taboo against mercenarism has been eroded, and its erosion is diagnostic of a return to a pre-Westphalian condition where the state does not monopolize legitimate violence. The chapter accepts McFate's evidence and extends it: the same pattern is visible in intelligence contracting (Booz Allen, Palantir), in border security (G4S, Serco), in logistics (KBR), in cyber (the offensive cyber services market), and — most consequentially — in the emerging market for AI-mediated decision support to states.
3. The Williams counter-read. Phil Williams's 2008 SSI monograph (bundled) is the pessimist's version: that the neomedieval reading is too optimistic, that state weakening in certain regions is producing not durable disorder but new dark ages. The chapter takes Williams's evidence — from Somalia, Iraq, and elsewhere — and integrates it with McFate's: the contractor economy is not just a symptom of dispersal but, in certain zones, the operative form of governance.
4. The specific mechanism of retention. Livery and maintenance depended on legal instruments (the indenture) that were technically illegal but universally practiced; the modern contractor economy depends on legal instruments (the contract, the security clearance, the export license, the ITAR waiver) that formalize the same relationship. In both periods, the great subject retains armed followers through a legal fiction that gestures at central authority while operating independently of it.
5. The specific mechanism of finance. Livery and maintenance were financed through rents, plunder, and central remittance in variable mix. The modern contractor economy is financed almost entirely through central remittance — the state pays the contractor — which makes the modern condition significantly *less* neomedieval than the fifteenth century in one important respect: the contractors have not developed independent fiscal bases. This will matter in Chapter 4 (the *condottieri*) and in Chapter 11 (the settlement).

6. The pending question. The chapter closes on the observation that the modern contractor economy has one feature the medieval original lacked: the state remains the paymaster. The condottieri who became sovereigns — Sforza above all — did so by developing independent fiscal bases (rents from cities, extraction from conquered territory). No modern PMSC has done this. Prigozhin tried and was killed. What does the modern condition look like where a contractor develops independent finance? The chapter identifies the frontier AI labs as the case to watch: they alone among modern contractors have revenue bases that could, in principle, sustain independent action.

Sources used.

- McFate, *Durable Disorder* (bundled LSE thesis) and *The Modern Mercenary* (Cambridge Library)
- Williams, *From the New Middle Ages to a New Dark Age* (bundled)
- Cerny 2005 (bundled) on the six characteristics, especially the fifth (property rights) and sixth (grey zones and black economy)
- K.B. McFarlane on English bastard feudalism (Cambridge Library)
- Vaughan on Valois Burgundy (Cambridge Library)
- Contamine, *War in the Middle Ages* (Cambridge Library) — for the *écorcheur* material
- Contemporary industry reporting on PMSCs, intelligence contractors, and the AI-lab-to-state relationship

Objection stress test. The strategic-studies revisionist's likely complaint: that the state's monopoly on legitimate violence is not as eroded as the neomedieval literature claims, and that PMSCs remain fundamentally dependent on state contracts. The chapter concedes the point about dependence, distinguishes the modern PMSC from the medieval condottiere on precisely this ground, and identifies the frontier AI lab as the anomalous case that behaves less like a PMSC and more like a proto-condottiere with an independent economic base.

Chapter 4 — The Condottieri

Purpose. Give the condottiere phenomenon its full historical due — Italian, not generalized — and use it to sharpen the analysis of the modern market for force. Include the two case studies the chapter title implies: Hawkwood and the emergence of the *compagnia di ventura*, and Sforza as the mercenary who became sovereign, which is the deepest historical parallel available to the Prigozhin question. Extend to the two other Italian institutional forms Kobrin gestured toward but the literature never developed: the Hansa as proto-platform commercial sovereignty (Baltic, not Italian, but treated in the chapter for structural reasons) and Venice as the surveillance-state-before-the-state.

Argument. The condottiere system is the neomedieval literature's own preferred parallel for modern PMSCs, but the literature has consistently underplayed three features of the Italian original that matter now: (1) the condottieri operated in a competitive market for force that included fiscally-capable city-states and independent territorial bases, which is what allowed mercenary-to-sovereign transitions like Sforza's; (2) the Hansa demonstrated that commercial actors could develop independent sovereign functions across a transnational network without

political incorporation, which is a much better parallel to the current platform economy than either the papacy or the Empire; (3) Venice developed, out of commercial necessity, the first surveillance state — the *Consiglio dei Dieci*, the *bocche di leone*, the *balestrieri* — three centuries before Louis XIV, and did so as a *republican* institution, which unsettles the assumption that modern surveillance is a state phenomenon.

Structure.

1. Hawkwood and the *compagnia di ventura*. The English routier who became the greatest condottiere of the fourteenth century, the White Company as the archetypal free company, the tactical innovation (dismounted men-at-arms plus longbowmen) exported to Italy from the Hundred Years' War. Drawn from Mallett's *Mercenaries and Their Masters* (Cambridge Library).
2. The system in operation. The *condotta* as a legal instrument; the market for force among the Italian city-states; the specific reasons the system was more stable in Italy than in France (fiscally-capable cities, competitive market, absence of dominant hegemon). This is important: the Italian condottieri were domesticated *by market competition*, not by state force.
3. Sforza as the sovereign who came from nothing. Francesco Sforza's rise from mercenary captain to Duke of Milan (1450) as the case of a condottiere developing an independent political base by marrying into a ruling house and exploiting a succession crisis. The chapter takes Sforza seriously as a model for what a condottiere-to-sovereign transition looks like — and specifies what conditions made it possible (fiscally weak central authority, fiscally strong city-state, dynastic vacuum, personal military reputation, marriage strategy).
4. The Prigozhin question, done properly. Prigozhin's arc — from restaurateur to caterer to warlord to failed coup leader — read against Sforza's arc. The chapter argues that Prigozhin failed not because the Sforza move is obsolete but because the modern strong state has captured the market for force in ways that make the Sforza move impossible from *below*. But the *Sforza move from above* — a state absorbing a condottiere and elevating him — is the pattern to watch, and the chapter identifies specific candidates: Palantir's fusion into US intelligence workflows, Anduril's absorption into DoD procurement, the frontier AI labs' developing security-clearance dependencies. These are Sforza-from-above rather than Sforza-from-below, and they are the modern pattern.
5. The Hansa as proto-platform. The Hanseatic League as a transnational commercial network with its own law (the *Hanserecht*), its own courts (the *Hansetag* and its subordinate diets), its own military capacity (the Hansa fleets, occasional naval wars with Denmark and England), and its own extraterritorial enclaves (the Kontors at Bergen, Bruges, London Steelyard, Novgorod). The chapter argues that this is a much better historical parallel to the modern hyperscaler platforms than either the Church or the Empire: a transnational commercial actor with legal, judicial, and coercive capacity operating across the sovereignty of others.
6. Venice as the surveillance-state-before-the-state. The Council of Ten, the *provveditori*, the *bocche di leone* denunciation system, the arsenal as centralized state manufacturing, the state debt (the *prestiti*) as the first sovereign bond market. Venice as the medieval polity

that most closely prefigures the modern surveillance state — and did so as a republic, not a monarchy. The chapter uses Venice to unsettle the assumption that modern surveillance is a Chinese or American phenomenon; it is a *state form* phenomenon, and any polity operating at commercial scale in a plural jurisdictional environment ends up with something like it.

7. Closing the diagnostic. Chapter 4 ends Part I with the observation that the neomedievalism literature has taught us to see the fragmentation but has not equipped us to see the pattern that ends it. Part II turns to that pattern.

Sources used.

- Mallett, *Mercenaries and Their Masters* (Cambridge Library)
- McFate, *Durable Disorder* (bundled) and *The Modern Mercenary* on modern parallels
- Kobrin 1998/1999 (bundled) on transnational commercial sovereignty as a Kobrin-anticipated pattern
- The classic Hansa historiography: Dollinger, *The German Hansa* (Cambridge Library); Jenks, various
- Lane, *Venice: A Maritime Republic* (Cambridge Library); Finlay on Venetian government
- Contemporary reporting on Wagner and Prigozhin (2022–2023), on Palantir/Anduril integration, on the AI-lab security-clearance apparatus

Objection stress test. The medievalist's likely complaint: that the Hansa was not a "proto-platform" and that reading it that way flattens its actual institutional character. The chapter concedes that the analogy is imperfect and specifies that the Hansa is being used as a *structural* parallel — a transnational commercial actor with legal, coercive, and jurisdictional capacity — rather than a functional one. The point is not that Amazon is the Hansa but that the modern state faces a problem the medieval state also faced: how to deal with a transnational commercial actor whose scale exceeds any single territorial sovereign's writ.

Part II — The Crisis

(The 1450 hinge, viewed from both sides of the Channel. Five chapters, approx. 55,000 words. This is where the book earns its causal claim: the mechanism that ended the medieval dispersal, identified in the specific decade in which it operated, then used to identify the same mechanism at work now.)

Chapter 5 — The Undermighty Kings

Purpose. Establish the mid-fifteenth-century sovereignty crisis as a pan-European condition, not an English pathology, by running Henry VI in parallel with Charles VI's madness, the Armagnac–Burgundian civil war, and the Ottoman succession crises of the same period. Set up the necessity of the response that follows in Chapters 10 and 11.

Argument. Hollow sovereignty — the crown as a legal fiction disconnected from executive capacity — was the modal condition of European monarchy in the second quarter of the fifteenth century. The English case (Henry VI's incapacity, the emergence of the Wars of the

Roses) has been treated as a distinctive English catastrophe; it was in fact one instance of a continental pattern. The importance of the chapter is that it establishes hollow sovereignty as a *systemic* failure mode of personalized constitutions under conditions of increased fiscal-military demand, not as a series of unfortunate accidents.

Structure.

1. Henry VI, treated straight. The incapacity of 1453–54; the loss of Normandy and Gascony coinciding with the incapacity; the emergence of Richard of York as protector; the failure of the political nation to construct a functioning regency. The Wars of the Roses as a symptom, not a cause.
2. Charles VI in retrospect. The reign that produced the crisis Henry VI inherited: the "poor mad king" of France, the intermittent lucidity, the regency of the dukes, the Armagnac–Burgundian civil war, the Treaty of Troyes and the disinheritance of the Dauphin. Vaughan's account of Burgundy in this period is the standard source; Famiglietti on Charles VI's court is the closer focus.
3. The Ottoman comparison. Murad II's abdication and return; the succession crises of the 1440s that preceded Mehmed II's stabilization; the *devşirme* system as the Ottoman solution to the same over-mighty-subject problem the Western monarchies were also confronting. Introduced here as a placeholder; developed in Chapter 11.
4. Hollow sovereignty as a modern condition. The chapter's contemporary payoff: the specific pattern of a legally-recognized central authority that cannot execute is observable now in specific polities — Somalia, Lebanon, Libya, arguably Ukraine before 2014, arguably significant portions of Central America — and in specific *functional* domains within otherwise-capable states (the US federal government's inability to execute on procurement at scale, the EU's inability to execute on defense, Japan's demographic incapacity). The chapter distinguishes carefully between hollow sovereignty as *territorial* failure (the Somalia case) and as *functional* failure (the procurement case), and argues that both are neomedieval in structure.
5. The specific dynamic. Undermighty kings do not produce over-mighty subjects; the causation runs the other way. Over-mighty subjects — great magnates whose retinues, fiscal bases, and clienteles rival the crown's — emerge first, and then a weak crown cannot resist them. This distinction matters because it means the modern condition (a US federal government facing platform actors with continental-scale infrastructure and independent political influence) is structurally analogous.

Sources used.

- Griffiths, *The Reign of King Henry VI* (Cambridge Library)
- Watts, *Henry VI and the Politics of Kingship* (Cambridge Library)
- Vaughan, *John the Fearless* and *Philip the Good* (Cambridge Library)
- Famiglietti, *Royal Intrigue: Crisis at the Court of Charles VI* (Cambridge Library)
- Kafadar, *Between Two Worlds*, on the early Ottoman period
- İnalcık, *The Ottoman Empire: The Classical Age* (Cambridge Library)

- Cerny 1998 / 2005 on hollow sovereignty as a Cerny characteristic

Objection stress test. The specialist's likely complaint: that Henry VI's incapacity was medically specific and Charles VI's was a different condition, and that comparing them as instances of "hollow sovereignty" flattens medical and political history. The chapter concedes that the medical particulars differ and specifies that the comparison is at the level of *institutional response* — the failure of regency mechanisms, the emergence of factional civil war, the erosion of central fiscal capacity — rather than of medical etiology.

Chapter 6 — 1450: The Year the Walls Fell

Purpose. The book's causal turn. Establish that between roughly 1449 and 1453, the price of decisive violence changed across Europe, and that the change is measurable, dateable, and technology-specific. This is the chapter that makes the whole book falsifiable: if the artillery revolution of the mid-fifteenth century did not in fact change the economics of sovereignty, the book's central mechanism fails.

Argument. The military revolution literature (Roberts, Parker, Rogers, Ayton, and the ongoing scholarly debate) has established beyond serious dispute that the introduction of effective siege artillery in the second quarter of the fifteenth century made previously impregnable fortifications indefensible within weeks rather than years. The Bureau brothers' siege train, developed under Charles VII, is the specific instrument whose specific operations can be traced. Formigny (April 1450), Castillon (July 1453), and the Normandy campaign between them (1449–1450) are the specific engagements in which the new capability was demonstrated. Only fiscally-capable central authorities could afford the trains; the barons whose military position rested on castle-holding became militarily obsolete within a generation; and the "new monarchies" that emerged in the following decades did so on the basis of this fiscal-military advantage. The chapter argues that this is the *decisive* moment in ending the medieval dispersal, and it argues so with sufficient specificity that the claim can be tested.

Structure.

1. The technological baseline. The state of European fortification circa 1400 (the developed high-medieval castle, effectively impregnable to any technology available to besiegers except starvation over months to years). The state of artillery circa 1400 (bombards effective against wooden structures and light masonry; incapable of reducing developed stone fortifications in reasonable time). The gap between them as the material foundation of the baronial military position.
2. The Bureau brothers. Jean and Gaspard Bureau, the *maîtres de l'artillerie* under Charles VII, and the specific innovations they introduced: standardized calibers, corned powder, iron shot, trunnions and improved carriages, the specialized *artilleurs* as a paid technical service. Contamine's *Guerre, état et société* is the standard source. The chapter treats the Bureau brothers as the technical protagonists of the whole book.
3. Formigny, April 1450. The engagement itself: the English relief force at Formigny, the French field artillery in action for the first time in a battle (as opposed to a siege), the culebrines that broke the English line before the melee. Formigny is important because it demonstrates that the new artillery was not only siege-relevant but tactically decisive.

4. The Normandy campaign, 1449–1450. The systematic reduction of Norman fortifications: Verneuil, Pont-Audemer, Lisieux, Bayeux, Caen, Falaise, Rouen. Sixty fortified places taken in fifteen months, when a decade earlier a single major siege could take a year. The chapter dwells on the temporal compression: the *speed* of the campaign is the evidence.
5. Castillon, July 1453. The engagement described in the introduction, returned to in full: Talbot's charge, the Bureau artillery position, the collapse of the English force, the political consequence. Castillon as the end of the Hundred Years' War, and – more importantly for the book's argument – as the end of a specific military-political order in which fortified magnate power could resist central authority.
6. The modern rhyme within the rhyme. Two contemporary moments of sudden imperial collapse used as comparative material: the fall of France in six weeks in May–June 1940, and the collapse of the US-backed government in Kabul in August 2021. Both are structurally similar to Normandy 1450: sudden capability shifts producing the collapse of an order that had appeared stable weeks earlier. The chapter is careful not to over-claim the analogy – Blitzkrieg and Taliban advance are not artillery revolutions – but uses them to make the temporal point: technological and organizational shifts can produce sovereign collapse on timescales the affected polities cannot process.
7. Setting up Chapter 10. The chapter closes by noting that the Bureau artillery was not deployed by great magnates because great magnates could not afford it. It required the fiscal capacity of the French crown – the *taille* extracted from the whole country – and it required the administrative capacity of a specialized technical service. Both fiscal and administrative capacities had preceded the artillery revolution but had not been decisive; artillery made them decisive. The chapter thus sets up Chapter 10's argument about the fiscal-military state as the response to the artillery revolution.

Sources used.

- Contamine, *Guerre, état et société à la fin du Moyen Âge* (Cambridge Library)
- Vale, *War and Chivalry* (Cambridge Library)
- Rogers (ed.), *The Military Revolution Debate* (Cambridge Library)
- Parker, *The Military Revolution* (Cambridge Library)
- DeVries, *Guns and Men in Medieval Europe* (Cambridge Library)
- Ayton and Price, *The Medieval Military Revolution* (Cambridge Library)
- Curry, *The Hundred Years War* (Cambridge Library)
- Allmand, *The Hundred Years War: England and France at War* (Cambridge Library)

Objection stress test. The military historian's likely complaint: that the "military revolution" thesis is contested and that Rogers has argued for an earlier revolution (the infantry revolution of the fourteenth century) as the more consequential one. The chapter engages this directly, argues that the infantry revolution was necessary but not sufficient for consolidation (because infantry could be raised by great magnates too), and identifies the artillery revolution as the specific step that shifted the fiscal threshold above what any subject could sustain.

Chapter 7 — Cade and the Communes

Purpose. Bring in the popular dimension of the crisis: the propertied-anxious revolt as a recurring European form. Jack Cade's Rebellion (1450), the Praguerie in France (1440), the earlier Ciompi legacy in Italy, and the various German peasant and urban risings of the fifteenth century as instances of a common pattern — subject populations reacting to the fiscal-military and administrative pressures of the emerging state by attempting either to restore an older constitution or to constitute a new political community below the level of the crown.

Argument. The neomedieval literature has largely ignored popular politics. The modern parallel — the populist wave of the 2010s and 2020s, the various movements against globalization and platform power, the emergence of anti-technocratic politics on both left and right — is comprehensible as a reaction to precisely the same pressures. The chapter argues that popular revolt is a *predictable* accompaniment of consolidation: the fiscal demands and administrative reach of the emerging state produce reactive movements from the propertied middle rather than from the truly poor, and those movements shape the settlement without preventing it.

Structure.

1. Cade's Rebellion, 1450. The specific grievances (misgovernment, favoritism, loss of France, financial exactions), the composition of the movement (yeomen, small gentry, urban artisans — the propertied middle, not the poor), the specific demands (the removal of favorites, the restoration of good government, the recall of Henry VI to responsible rule). Cade's demands as *conservative* rather than revolutionary — the pattern that will recur.
2. The Praguerie, 1440. The revolt of the French princes with popular support against Charles VII's military reforms, specifically against the establishment of the *compagnies d'ordonnance* and the extension of the *taille*. Read as a *reactionary* movement in the precise sense: against the fiscal-military state.
3. The Ciompi legacy. The Florentine Ciompi revolt of 1378 as the earlier archetype; the persistence of Ciompi-style urban politics in fifteenth-century Italy; the specific way that Italian city politics generated propertied-anxious movements that were absorbed rather than defeated by the emerging *signorie*.
4. The German pattern. The *Bundschuh* movements, the urban revolts of the 1460s and 1470s, the persistence of anti-fiscal politics in the Empire. Setting up the eventual explosion in 1525.
5. The propertied-anxious revolt as recurring European form. The chapter identifies the pattern's structural features: leadership from the propertied middle, demands framed as restoration rather than revolution, focus on fiscal grievance and corruption of central authority, absorption into the eventual settlement through selective concession rather than defeat.
6. The modern parallel. The populist wave of the 2010s–2020s — Brexit, Trump, the *gilets jaunes*, the Five Star Movement, AfD, the various anti-globalization movements of the left — read as a Cade-and-Praguerie-scale reaction to the same pressures. The chapter is careful to specify: the modern populists are not "medieval" in any romantic sense; they are structurally analogous in the specific sense that they arise from the propertied middle in

reaction to the fiscal, administrative, and cultural reach of an emerging order that they experience as illegitimate.

7. The critical asymmetry. In the medieval case, the propertied-anxious revolts *did not prevent the consolidation*. They shaped it — the settlements that emerged in the 1470s–1530s incorporated some of the reform demands and defeated others — but they did not stop the artillery state from being built. The chapter argues that the modern populist wave is likely to have the same effect: it will shape the eventual settlement, but it will not prevent the Tudor turn.

Sources used.

- Harvey, *Jack Cade's Rebellion of 1450* (Cambridge Library)
- Watts, *Henry VI and the Politics of Kingship* (Cambridge Library)
- Contamine on the *compagnies d'ordonnance* and the Praguerie (Cambridge Library)
- Najemy, *A History of Florence 1200–1575* (Cambridge Library)
- Brady, Oberman, and Tracy (eds.), *Handbook of European History 1400–1600* (Cambridge Library)
- Contemporary political science on the populist wave (Mudde, Norris, Inglehart) as the comparative material

Objection stress test. The political scientist's likely complaint: that comparing Cade to modern populism is either trivial (all populism is structurally similar) or misleading (the differences matter more than the similarities). The chapter takes the second complaint seriously and specifies: the useful comparison is not between Cade and Trump but between the pattern of propertied-anxious revolt-under-consolidation across cases, and specifically the observation that such revolts shape but do not prevent consolidation.

Chapter 8 — Private Justice, Private War

Purpose. Treat the legal grey zones of the fifteenth century — private feud, vendetta, *Fehde*, sanctuary, ecclesiastical jurisdiction, mercantile law, admiralty — as the operative form of law in the dispersal period, and use the treatment to illuminate Cerny's sixth characteristic (legal grey zones and the black economy) in the modern context.

Argument. When the public sword rusts, private force fills the gap. The fifteenth century operated on a plural legal foundation in which the king's peace was one of many jurisdictions competing for the enforcement business, and the settlement that eventually emerged (the sixteenth-century assertion of royal justice as monopolist) was a consequence of the fiscal-military consolidation, not its precondition. The chapter argues that the modern equivalent is observable now in the proliferation of private arbitration, platform-adjudicated dispute resolution, offshore financial jurisdictions, the crypto legal experiment, and the specific pattern of major disputes migrating to fora chosen by the parties rather than imposed by the sovereign. This is the sixth Cerny characteristic operating in full flower.

Structure.

1. The English feud tradition. The Paston Letters as the primary source: the Pastons vs. the Dukes of Norfolk and Suffolk, the specific way in which access to royal justice was itself a factional resource, the operation of the assize courts under conditions of local magnate dominance. The Pastons as the paradigmatic case of propertied-gentry navigating a plural legal environment.
2. The German *Fehde*. The persistence of the feud as legally-recognized private war within the Empire, the *Landfrieden* peace movements as attempted restrictions, the specific case of Götz von Berlichingen and the persistence of feuding into the sixteenth century.
3. The Italian vendetta. The vendetta as an operative institution in fifteenth-century Italy, the specific relationship between vendetta and the emerging *signorie* (which tolerated vendetta at street level while suppressing it among the great families), the transition to Renaissance princely justice.
4. The plural legal environment more broadly. Sanctuary and its erosion; benefit of clergy; the *lex mercatoria*; admiralty jurisdiction; the specific way in which a fifteenth-century merchant or noble navigated multiple legal systems as a matter of course. The medieval original of what we now call "regulatory arbitrage."
5. The modern parallel. The rise of private arbitration as the operative form of high-value commercial dispute resolution; the ISDS regime and its critics; platform-adjudicated disputes (App Store rejections, YouTube monetization decisions, Amazon seller suspensions) as a new form of private jurisdiction operating at scale; the offshore financial jurisdictions and their persistence; the crypto legal experiment (from Bitcoin's original ambition to DeFi to the current wave of specialized crypto courts). All read as Cerny's sixth characteristic in operation.
6. The public sword. The chapter closes by noting that the medieval settlement to the plural legal environment was the assertion of royal justice as monopolist — the sixteenth-century equity courts, the Council of the North and the Marches, the *parlements* of France, the *audiencias* of Spain — and that this assertion was possible only because the fiscal-military consolidation had provided the resources to enforce it. The modern equivalent is the emerging pattern of state assertion over private and platform-adjudicated disputes: the EU's DMA and DSA as canonical assertions, the US Section 230 debate, the antitrust wave, the crypto regulatory turn. Foreshadowing Chapter 11.

Sources used.

- Bellamy, *Crime and Public Order in England in the Later Middle Ages* (Cambridge Library)
- Castor, *The Paston Letters* (Cambridge Library)
- Zmora, *State and Nobility in Early Modern Germany* (Cambridge Library) for the *Fehde*
- Muir, *Mad Blood Stirring* (Cambridge Library) for Italian vendetta
- Cerny 1998 / 2005 (bundled) on the sixth characteristic
- Contemporary reporting on private arbitration, platform adjudication, and the crypto legal experiment
- The literature on regulatory arbitrage (Pistor, *The Code of Capital*, especially — a bridge text between the neomedieval frame and the modern legal economy)

Objection stress test. The legal historian's likely complaint: that the medieval plural legal environment is being romanticized, and that the actual operation of feud and vendetta was violent, arbitrary, and grim. The chapter concedes the point and specifies that it is *not* romanticizing the medieval original; it is arguing that the plural legal environment was violent, arbitrary, and grim, that its erosion was a genuine achievement of the consolidating state, and that a return to plural legal environments now — visible in the ISDS regime and in platform adjudication — should be understood in the same terms.

Chapter 9 — The King's Two Bodies, Broken

Purpose. Treat the failure of personalized constitutions under conditions of increased demand as the deepest structural feature of the crisis, using Ernst Kantorowicz's frame (the king's two bodies — the natural body that dies and the political body that persists) and its breakdown under conditions where the natural body cannot execute. This is the chapter that carries the author's specific expertise on regency and incapacity, and it is the most philosophically ambitious chapter of Part II.

Argument. The medieval constitution was fundamentally personal: authority was vested in a specific individual whose natural body was expected to execute the political body's functions. This worked adequately when the executive demands on the natural body were modest; it broke down catastrophically when they were not. The crisis of the mid-fifteenth century is legible as a crisis of personalization: the demands on the natural body of the king (Henry VI, Charles VI, and the various regents) had grown to a point where personal execution was impossible, and no institutional substitute yet existed. The Tudor settlement, and its continental analogs, invented the institutional substitute — the bureaucratic state — as the political body's new executive apparatus. The chapter's contemporary payoff is to identify the modern equivalent: the personalization of executive authority in the presidencies, prime ministerships, and platform CEO offices of the current period, and the structural pressure toward institutional substitutes that is already visible.

Structure.

1. Kantorowicz re-read. The theological genealogy of the two-body doctrine, its late-medieval maturity, its specific vulnerability under conditions of executive overload.
2. Henry VI's incapacity as a two-body crisis. The specific way in which the political body of the crown depended on the natural body's capacity, and the constitutional confusion produced when the natural body could not execute. The failure of the protectorate as an institutional response.
3. Charles VI's madness as the deeper case. The intermittent lucidity that prevented a stable regency, the emergence of the ducal factions as substitutes, the Armagnac-Burgundian civil war as the pathological form of the substitute. The chapter treats Charles VI as the more instructive case because the intermittent nature of his incapacity is what generated the deepest constitutional crisis.
4. The regency solutions. The specific institutional experiments of the fifteenth century — protectorates, councils, dual monarchies — read as attempts to construct an executive

apparatus that did not require the natural body. Their consistent failure is treated as evidence of the structural nature of the problem.

5. The Elton thesis, in miniature. G.R. Elton's *Tudor Revolution in Government* (Cambridge Library, and available via Cambridge Core) argued that the 1530s in England constituted a bureaucratic revolution — the transition from medieval household government to modern institutional government — under Thomas Cromwell's direction. The thesis is contested (the Starkey and Coleman critiques are the standard rejoinders), and the chapter engages the debate. But the core point — that the personal constitution gave way, under fiscal-military pressure, to an institutional one — is defensible even in the revised historiography.
6. The modern personalization. Contemporary executive politics — the presidentialization of parliamentary systems, the emergence of the founder-CEO as the platform sovereign, the specific way in which figures like Musk, Zuckerberg, and Xi combine personal authority with continental-scale institutional apparatus — read as a modern two-body problem. The natural body is being asked to execute a political body's functions at a scale that no natural body can sustain. Institutional substitutes are being improvised (the office of the presidency's staff, the platform's operating leadership, the party's central committee), but they are not yet mature.
7. The pending settlement. The chapter closes by observing that the medieval settlement to the two-body crisis was the institutionalization of the political body in the bureaucratic state — offices, records, procedures, salaried officials whose loyalty was to the office rather than the person. The modern equivalent is the emerging bureaucratization of platform, party, and executive authority, and the chapter identifies specific indicators to watch: the professionalization of platform trust-and-safety operations, the emergence of institutional AI governance (as opposed to founder-driven policy), the routinization of executive orders and party doctrine.

Sources used.

- Kantorowicz, *The King's Two Bodies* (Cambridge Library)
- Elton, *The Tudor Revolution in Government* (Cambridge Library and Cambridge Core)
- Starkey, *The Reign of Henry VIII* (Cambridge Library) — for the revisionist critique
- Coleman and Starkey (eds.), *Revolution Reassessed* (Cambridge Library)
- Watts on Henry VI (as above)
- Famiglietti on Charles VI (as above)
- Guenée, *States and Rulers in Later Medieval Europe* (Cambridge Library)

Objection stress test. The Elton revisionists' likely complaint: that the Tudor Revolution thesis has been substantially qualified by the last forty years of scholarship, and that using it as the historical anchor of a modern argument is naïve. The chapter takes the point seriously and specifies that the argument does not require the strong Elton thesis (a single revolutionary decade under Cromwell); it requires only the weaker claim that fifteenth- and sixteenth-century Europe saw a sustained transition from personal to institutional government, which is not contested.

Part III — The Settlement

(The new monarchies, and ours. Three chapters, approx. 40,000 words. The predictive phase. This is where the book delivers its answer to the two open questions in the existing literature: who is the modern Tudor state, and what is its artillery?)

Chapter 10 — The Artillery State

Purpose. The book's central causal chapter. Argue in detail that the mid-fifteenth-century military revolution produced the fiscal-military state as its response, and identify the specific institutional inventions — the *compagnies d'ordonnance*, the *taille*, the specialized artillery service, the standing army financed by permanent taxation — as the mechanism by which sovereignty was re-consolidated. This chapter carries the causal weight for the whole book.

Argument. Between 1445 and 1500, France, England, Spain, and the Ottoman Empire — and to a lesser but still identifiable extent Burgundy (before its dissolution), the Habsburg lands, and the Italian *signorie* — invented a new kind of political community: the fiscal-military state. The invention was driven by the artillery revolution and by the parallel developments in infantry organization; it required permanent taxation, which required legal-administrative capacity that did not previously exist; and it produced, as a consequence, a state that could suppress the great subjects because it could afford force at a scale they could not match. The chapter argues that this is the *repeatable* mechanism of Western state formation, and its identification is the book's most important claim.

Structure.

1. Charles VII's *compagnies d'ordonnance*, 1445. The specific reform: fifteen companies of one hundred *lances* each, permanently retained, salaried by the crown, quartered under crown discipline, disbandable only by the crown. Europe's first standing army since the late Roman Empire. Drawn from Contamine as the definitive source.
2. The *taille* as permanent taxation. The specific transition: from occasional taxation granted by the Estates for specific purposes to permanent taxation levied by royal ordinance, the political battles that made it possible (the acquiescence of the Estates General in 1439, the Praguerie's defeat in 1440), the administrative apparatus (the *élections*, the *généralités*) that made it collectable. The *taille* as the fiscal engine of the artillery state.
3. The Bureau artillery service in institutional form. The transition from artillery-as-technology (Chapter 6) to artillery-as-institution: the *maître de l'artillerie* as a great office of the crown, the arsenal at the Bastille, the salaried *canonniers* and *artilleurs*, the standardized calibers and procurement chains. Contamine again as the source.
4. Louis XI as the exemplar. Louis XI's reign (1461–83) as the case of the artillery state operating in fully mature form: the swallowing of Burgundy after Charles the Bold's death at Nancy 1477, the systematic reduction of the appanage principalities, the diplomatic use of fiscal resources ("the universal spider"), the emergence of a professional royal service (Commynes, La Balue). Read against the earlier over-mighty-subject problem: Louis XI's France is the first case in which the crown is systematically stronger than any of its subjects, and the difference is measurable in the fiscal accounts.

5. The Burgundian counter-case. Charles the Bold's Burgundy had superb artillery — probably the best in Europe — and it lost anyway. The Swiss pike squares at Grandson, Murten, and Nancy defeated Burgundian artillery because massed disciplined infantry, cheap to raise and cheap to sustain relative to horse, could close the gap before the guns could reload. The chapter dwells on this because it is the crucial inoculation against artillery determinism: even in the consolidation era, cheap distributed force could defeat capital-intensive force under the right doctrinal conditions. But — the chapter argues — the Swiss won battles and lost the war of political form: their victory produced no consolidation of Swiss sovereignty comparable to what happened in France, because pike squares alone did not require or produce the fiscal-administrative apparatus that artillery required. The lesson is that decisive military technology matters less by itself than through the fiscal and administrative institutions it forces the polity to build.
6. Technology → finance → sovereignty. The chapter's argument in its most compressed form. Artillery required permanent finance; permanent finance required administrative capacity; administrative capacity required the suppression of intermediate authorities that stood between the crown and the taxable subject. The causal chain is legible in the sequence of institutional inventions across the mid-fifteenth century.
7. The modern parallel, sketched. The chapter closes by moving the same causal chain to the present. Modern decisive military capability (the compute-satellite-foundry-munitions stack) requires permanent finance at a scale no subordinate authority can sustain. Permanent finance at that scale requires administrative capacity — including the legibility infrastructure to identify taxable capacity — that no subordinate authority can build. Therefore: only polities that can pay for the stack can execute at the new scale, and only polities with the legibility infrastructure to sustain the payments can build the stack. The chapter identifies four polities that meet or plausibly meet both conditions: the United States, China, the European Union (as a canonical rather than military authority — a special case treated in Chapter 11), and possibly India. The rest will be clients of one of these four.

Sources used.

- Contamine, *Guerre, état et société* (Cambridge Library) as the definitive source
- Contamine (ed.), *War and Competition Between States* (Cambridge Library)
- Rogers (ed.), *The Military Revolution Debate* (Cambridge Library)
- Parker, *The Military Revolution* (Cambridge Library)
- Vale, *War and Chivalry* (Cambridge Library)
- Vaughan on Charles the Bold (Cambridge Library)
- Kendall, *Louis XI* (Cambridge Library)
- Commynes, *Mémoires* (in standard modern edition)
- Contemporary primary sources on the compute-foundry stack: CHIPS Act legislation, EU Chips Act, Chinese Big Fund II documentation, DoD industrial base assessments

Objection stress test. The techno-optimist's likely complaint: that the modern compute stack does not require permanent taxation because it is financed privately. The chapter's answer: the

civilian compute stack is financed privately; the *military-relevant* stack (satellite constellations for ISR, hyperscale training compute for classified applications, munitions industrial base for peer conflict) is financed by permanent public expenditure at a scale visible in the CHIPS Act, the National Defense Authorization Acts, and their Chinese and EU equivalents. The public financing of the military-relevant stack is precisely the artillery-state pattern in the present.

Chapter 11 — The New Monarchies

Purpose. Complete the historical case by running the Tudor playbook comparatively across Henry VII's England, Louis XI's France (extended from Chapter 10), Ferdinand and Isabella's Spain, the early Habsburg lands, and the Ottoman Empire under Mehmed II and Bayezid II. Then use the developed comparative pattern to make the book's principal predictive claim: the modern Tudor states already exist in embryonic form, and the specific indicators of their emergence are visible now.

Argument. The Tudor pattern is not English and not idiosyncratic. Between roughly 1470 and 1530, five or six European polities executed variants of the same set of moves: (1) fiscal reform to establish permanent taxation and central revenue collection; (2) subordination or absorption of great subjects through legal, financial, and where necessary military means; (3) domestication of the market for force through the establishment of standing companies or their equivalent; (4) canonical assertion of central authority over rival jurisdictions (the Church, the free cities, the military orders, the great franchises); (5) mobilization of the new communications technology (print, in the sixteenth century) as an instrument of the state's legibility and doctrinal reach. The chapter runs each of these five moves comparatively, and then argues that all five are observable now in the leading candidate polities.

Structure.

1. Henry VII's playbook. Chamber finance, the reduction of livery and maintenance, the Court of Star Chamber, the bonds and recognizances, the Council Learned in the Law. Henry VII as the technician of consolidation, less spectacular than Louis XI but more instructive institutionally. Drawn from Gunn and Chrimes (Cambridge Library).
2. Louis XI, extended from Chapter 10. The consolidation completed under his son and grandson — Charles VIII's Italian intervention as the first exercise of the mature fiscal-military state in continental adventure, and the specific way the mature apparatus functioned.
3. Ferdinand and Isabella. The *hermandades* as the domestication of local order; the domestication of the military orders (Santiago, Calatrava, Alcántara) by absorption into the crown after 1476; the Inquisition as the canonical instrument of religious uniformity fused with royal administration; the expulsion and conversion policies as extreme versions of the legibility move. Elliott's *Imperial Spain* as the standard source.
4. The Ottoman *devşirme* as the most radical variant. The systematic extraction of Christian boys, their conversion and training, their deployment as *kul* — slaves of the sultan whose loyalty was to the office and not to family, region, or faith. The *devşirme* as the most successful solution to the over-mighty-subject problem in the fifteenth century: the polity

produces its own administrative and military class from raw material rather than negotiating with existing elites. Drawn from İnalçık and Kafadar.

5. Print, and the state swallowing the Church. The chapter's crucial move: the argument that print was to the sixteenth-century state what artillery had been to the fifteenth-century state — a technology that changed the economics of political community and that only certain kinds of polity could exploit. Henry VIII's supremacy — the state's swallowing of the Church's functions in England — was executable only because print made a national vernacular canonical form of religion administrable. The chapter dwells on this because it is the specific move that most closely prefigures the modern condition.
6. The five moves, restated. Fiscal reform (permanent central taxation with administrative apparatus); subordination of great subjects; domestication of the market for force; canonical assertion over rival jurisdictions; mobilization of communications technology for legibility. The chapter presents these as the *repeatable* pattern.
7. The predictive translation. Each of the five moves has an observable contemporary form:
 - **Fiscal reform.** The emerging apparatus of digital tax administration, cross-border reporting standards (CRS, FATCA, Pillar Two), and the specific extension of fiscal reach into platform economies. The BEPS process and its successors as the fiscal-consolidation apparatus of the modern age.
 - **Subordination of great subjects.** The antitrust wave in the US and EU; the Chinese platform crackdown post-2020; the emerging regulatory subordination of frontier AI labs; the specific pattern of state absorption of critical private capacity (Palantir, Anduril, the frontier labs' security clearances).
 - **Domestication of the market for force.** The regularization of PMSCs into state procurement chains in the US; the destruction of independent mercenary capacity in Russia after Prigozhin; China's suppression of independent security capacity; the specific pattern of state re-monopolization of decisive force.
 - **Canonical assertion.** The EU's DMA, DSA, and AI Act as the paradigmatic case; the US antitrust wave and its extraterritorial reach; China's cyberspace and data laws with extraterritorial claims; the emerging global architecture of AI safety regulation.
 - **Mobilization of communications technology.** The state absorption of AI capacity as the equivalent of Henry VIII's absorption of the Church. Not breaking the platforms but *nationalizing their functions*: state-controlled foundation models (French Mistral with state backing, the UK AI Safety Institute, US Executive Order on AI, China's National AI Lab), state-controlled cloud and identity infrastructure (GAIA-X, India Stack, Chinese digital identity), state-controlled payment rails (CBDCs, the FedNow/UPI/e-CNY progression).
8. The book's central prediction. The chapter states the prediction plainly: the state will not break the platforms; the state will nationalize their functions. The pattern of nationalization will differ by bloc — US absorption through security-clearance and defense-industrial-base integration, EU absorption through canonical regulatory assertion, Chinese absorption through fused party-state ownership, EU-adjacent middle powers (India, Brazil, possibly a post-Brexit UK) through sovereign-cloud and sovereign-AI strategies. The interstitial spaces between the blocs will remain neomedieval, and the book identifies

where they are: the failed and failing states of the Sahel and Central America; the offshore financial jurisdictions; the crypto ecosystem in its unregulated forms; the ungoverned parts of the internet.

Sources used.

- Gunn, *Henry VII's New Men and the Making of Tudor England* (Cambridge Library)
- Chrimes, *Henry VII* (Cambridge Library)
- Elliott, *Imperial Spain 1469–1716* (Cambridge Library)
- İnalcık, *The Ottoman Empire: The Classical Age* (Cambridge Library)
- Kafadar, *Between Two Worlds* (Cambridge Library)
- Eisenstein, *The Printing Press as an Agent of Change* (Cambridge Library) for the print material
- Elton, *Tudor Revolution and England Under the Tudors* (Cambridge Library)
- Friedrichs 2004 (Cambridge Library / Brill) on the neomedieval renaissance in global governance
- Zielonka on the EU as canonical authority (Cambridge Library)
- Contemporary primary sources: CHIPS Act, EU AI Act, DMA/DSA texts, Chinese platform regulations, DoD industrial base assessments, sovereign-AI initiatives

Objection stress test. Two objections, both engaged in the chapter:

- The great-power-competition frame's likely complaint: that the emerging pattern is a return to Westphalian great-power politics, not a Tudor consolidation, and that framing it as Tudor is either a category error or a rhetorical flourish. The chapter's answer: what looks Westphalian from the outside (three or four great powers competing) is internally Tudor — each bloc is executing the five moves against its own great subjects, and the international competition is downstream of the internal consolidation. This is a testable distinction: if the blocs' internal politics look like great-power balancing against subjects, the great-power frame is right; if they look like fiscal-canonical-administrative consolidation, the Tudor frame is right. The chapter argues that the evidence favors the second reading.
- The libertarian/decentralist complaint: that the Tudor prediction ignores the countervailing technological forces — crypto, distributed compute, encrypted communications, open-source AI — that are pushing in the opposite direction. The chapter takes the complaint seriously and specifies that these forces are real but are operating in the *interstitial* spaces between the blocs, not against the blocs' internal consolidation. They are the modern equivalent of the *écorceurs* and the pirates: real, persistent, and shaping the settlement, but not preventing it.

Chapter 12 — Not Modernity, But Tudor

Purpose. The book's synthesis. State the settlement that the argument predicts, describe what it will look like from inside and outside, answer the central military-technology question honestly, and close with the implications for the constituencies who will make the settlement or be made by it.

Argument. The settlement to expect is not a return to Westphalian modernity, and it is not the "end of history" restoration of liberal internationalism. It is a Tudor settlement, in the precise sense: personal-charismatic rule atop bureaucratic machinery, delivery-plus-spectacle legitimacy, transnational lords leashed rather than destroyed, and the state operating through the absorbed functions of the platforms it once feared. The military-technology question is answered asymmetrically: the low end of the stack decentralizes (drones, cyber, distributed autonomy — the modern longbow) while the decisive layer concentrates (compute, foundries, orbital ISR, sustained munitions — the modern cannon), and the polities that hold the decisive layer will consolidate while those that do not will fragment or become clients.

Structure.

1. What the settlement looks like from outside. The observable pattern in fifteen to twenty-five years: three or four blocs (US-led maritime, Chinese continental, EU regulatory-canonical, possibly Indian) each with domesticated platform apparatus, integrated security-industrial base, absorbed private force, and canonical assertion over subjects. Interstitial neomedieval spaces persisting in the gaps. Superficial resemblance to nineteenth-century great-power politics, structural resemblance to sixteenth-century composite monarchies.
2. What the settlement looks like from inside. The lived experience of subjects under the Tudor state: personalized executive authority backed by durable bureaucracy; identity, payment, and communications infrastructure operated as extensions of state administration; a legally-plural but *hierarchically* plural system in which state courts sit above platform arbitration sits above private ordering; delivery-and-spectacle legitimacy in place of representative accountability; a persistent low-grade legibility that the medieval subject would have recognized only under the reach of the Inquisition or the Ottoman *devşirme*.
3. Who is Henry VII, and what is his artillery? The chapter names candidates and argues among them:
 - **The United States** as the most probable Henry VII case, executing the five moves haphazardly and half-consciously through the security-industrial base, the emerging AI-lab-to-state fusion, the CHIPS Act and its successors, the antitrust wave, and the specific pattern of state absorption of critical private capacity. Its "artillery" is the compute-foundry-satellite-munitions stack.
 - **China** as the case where the settlement has already been substantially achieved. Xi's post-2020 platform crackdown as the Gregorian moment; the fused party-state-platform apparatus as the finished form; the developmental state as the bureaucratic machinery beneath charismatic rule. Its "artillery" is the same stack, achieved by a different route (state-directed rather than state-absorbing).

- **The European Union** as the anomalous case: no army, no full-stack industrial base, but the most developed canonical apparatus in the world. The chapter argues that the EU is Tudor in only one of the five moves (canonical assertion) and that its position is structurally unstable — it will either develop the fiscal-military and administrative capacity to complete the settlement or be reduced to a client of the US bloc. The DMA and the AI Act as the leading indicators.
 - **India** as the possible fourth case, executing a distinctive variant through India Stack (the sovereign-legibility apparatus) and through demographic-industrial scale.
 - **Everyone else** as clients of one of the four, or as inhabitants of the interstitial neomedieval spaces.
4. The military-technology question, answered. The chapter takes the position it foreshadowed in the introduction: our decisive military technology is *asymmetrically* cannon. The low end is longbow — Ukraine 2022–2024 as the demonstration case, the FPV drone as the modern crossbow, the persistence of cheap-precision insurgent capacity as a Cerny "durable disorder" feature — but the *decisive* layer is more capital-intensive than gunpowder ever was. Only three or four polities can build satellite constellations at scale, leading-node foundries, hyperscale compute, sustained peer-conflict munitions industrial base. The consequence is that low-end violence will remain distributed (the Cade rebellions of our age) while decisive war will remain concentrated (the artillery states of our age). This is the honest answer to the introduction's question, and the chapter defends it against the two most serious objections: that Ukraine has already shown the longbow winning (the chapter's answer: Ukraine has shown the longbow raising the price of aggression, not defeating a full-stack adversary), and that open-source AI and distributed compute will erode the concentration (the chapter's answer: possible but not evident, and the leading indicators point the other way).
5. The two open gaps, closed. The chapter states plainly the two contributions the book makes to the neomedievalism literature:
- **Platforms as universalisms, institutionalized.** The chapter argues that Chapters 2 and 11 together provide the treatment Kobrin sketched in 1998 and the literature did not develop: a formal account of the platform universalisms as canonical authorities with doctrine, sanction, and jurisdictional claim, and of the state's response as the absorption rather than the destruction of their functions.
 - **The re-consolidation, mechanism identified.** The chapter argues that Chapters 6, 10, and 11 together provide the treatment the literature has never attempted: the specific causal mechanism (military capital-intensification producing fiscal-administrative consolidation) that ended the medieval dispersal, and the identification of the same mechanism operating in the present. The pendulum's return swing is no longer unclaimed territory.
6. The implications, briefly. The chapter closes with the implications for the constituencies the author briefs — insurers (Lloyd's, the reinsurers, the specialty lines), endowments (the Ivy and Oxbridge endowment complexes and their institutional peers), sovereign wealth funds, family offices, and the strategic-services industry. The Tudor settlement will be catastrophic for some asset classes and enormously profitable for others; the specific asset-class implications are drawn without spelling out actionable investment guidance. The

chapter is careful to remain a work of comparative historical analysis, not a work of investment advice, but the implications for the constituencies who will read it are made available.

7. Closing image. Return to Castillon. The Bureau brothers' artillery is not the whole of the modern condition, and the modern equivalent is not simply guns and foundries. But the *pattern* — capital-intensive decisive capability requiring fiscal-administrative state capacity, producing consolidation, ending a period of durable disorder — is the same pattern. The book has argued that the pattern is repeatable, that it is repeating, and that the settlement it produces will define the political community of the next century. Not modernity, but Tudor.

Sources used.

- Elton, *England Under the Tudors* (Cambridge Library) — for the settled Tudor case as the historical anchor
- Elliott, Gunn, Chrimes, İnalcık, Vaughan on the continental cases
- The full apparatus of the neomedievalism literature, brought together
- Contemporary primary sources on each of the four candidate polities' consolidation moves
- The strategic-studies literature on great-power competition — engaged and dissented from

Objection stress test. The final objection to engage: that the whole argument is deterministic and ignores contingency. The chapter's answer: the argument is *conditional*, not deterministic. If the leading indicators identified throughout the book move in the opposite direction — decisive military capability decentralizes, legibility infrastructure fragments, platform universalisms consolidate their independence — the Tudor prediction fails. The book has staked itself on the current trajectory of the indicators, and the reader is invited to test the prediction against the observable evidence over the next fifteen years.

Coda: A Note on Method and Sources

(Approx. 4,000 words, following Ch. 12. Not numbered as a chapter.)

A short methodological essay explaining how the book was constructed:

1. The relationship between the historical and contemporary chapters. The book does not argue that history repeats; it argues that specific mechanisms operate under specific conditions, and that where the conditions recur the mechanisms recur. This is a claim about causal structure, not about historical determinism.
2. The comparative register. Every chapter that leans on English evidence is paired with at least two continental cases, and disanalogies are flagged. The rule is stated explicitly: no single-polity argument.
3. The sourcing discipline. The neomedievalism literature is used as the analytical spine of the argument; the medieval historiography is used as the empirical foundation for the historical claims; contemporary primary sources (regulatory instruments, industrial-policy legislation, procurement filings, platform terms of service) are used as the empirical foundation for the contemporary claims. Where the neomedievalism literature is

speculative, the book acknowledges the speculation; where it is empirically grounded, the book cites the grounding.

4. What the book does not claim. It does not claim to predict specific events. It does not claim that any specific polity will succeed in executing the Tudor settlement. It does not claim that the settlement will be desirable, or stable, or moral. It claims only that the mechanism is operating, that the settlement is predicted by the mechanism, and that the leading indicators are visible.
5. The debt to Bull, and the disagreement with him. Bull said the evidence was insufficient. The book says the evidence is now sufficient, but for a different conclusion than Bull's hesitant embrace of the neomedieval thesis: for the conclusion that the neomedieval condition is a transitional phase in a pendulum that is now swinging back.

Apparatus

Appendix A: The Neomedievalism Literature, Annotated

A working bibliography of the neomedievalism literature, annotated with the specific arguments each item contributes and the specific chapters in which each is engaged. The apparatus reproduces the reading dossier already compiled, in the form of a scholarly appendix.

Appendix B: The Comparative Register — Polities Discussed

A tabular reference identifying, for each chapter, the polities covered, the specific institutions and events treated, and the primary sources cited. This is the transparency instrument: any reader can trace the comparative claims back to their evidence.

Appendix C: Leading Indicators

A specification of the observable indicators — measurable, dated, sourced — against which the book's central prediction can be tested. Ten to fifteen indicators, each with a current baseline and a directional prediction, so that the reader in ten years can score the book.

Appendix D: A Reader's Guide to the Neomedievalism Literature

A short essay identifying, for the reader who wants to pursue the subject further, the essential sequence of the primary literature: Bull, Friedrichs, Cerny, Kobrin, McFate, Williams, Zielonka, Slaughter, Holsinger, Rengger, and the newer edge of the field (Friedrichs 2004; Cerny's *Heterarchy in World Politics*, 2023). This is the reading program the introduction referenced, presented for the reader who wants to become expert in the framework the book extends.

Structural notes and length target

- **Total target length.** Approximately 145,000 words for the main text, plus approximately 15,000 words of apparatus. Serious trade press territory (Penguin, Farrar Straus, Yale, Princeton) rather than academic monograph.
- **Chapter distribution.** Introduction, ~12,000 words. Part I (four chapters), ~45,000 words. Part II (five chapters), ~55,000 words. Part III (three chapters), ~40,000 words. Coda, ~4,000 words. Apparatus, ~15,000 words.
- **Register.** Serious but readable. The model is closer to Tooze's *Wages of Destruction* or Judt's *Postwar* than to a pure academic monograph. Footnotes are full but confined to the apparatus and to the notes at the back; the text itself carries the argument.
- **Visual apparatus.** A plate section is planned: Bureau-brothers ordnance, Castillon, the Norman siege campaign map, the compagnies d'ordonnance in muster, Louis XI's Plessis, the *devşirme* processions, the first printed pages of the vernacular Bible, and — for the modern parallels — the CHIPS Act signing, the Chinese platform-crackdown enforcement notices, the DMA/DSA gatekeeper designations. Approximately sixteen plates, integrated across the three parts.
- **Comparative register enforcement.** Every chapter memo (the Claude Code brief file) must specify: (a) the primary polity treated; (b) at least two comparator polities; (c) the disanalogies flagged. This is the Buff Box provenance discipline ported into the research pipeline.

Endnote for the Claude Code pipeline

The next step, if you take this outline forward, is the master research-brief prompt: a parameterized template that will be instantiated once per chapter and run through Claude Code against this repo, with the provenance gate, the comparative register, and the objection stress test built in. Every chapter session gets its own folder (`brief.md`, `memo.md`, `sources.md`, `critiques.md`, `draft.md`), and every action visible as a diff.

The neomedievalism reading bundle, and the Cambridge-alumni-accessible paywalled originals, together constitute the seed corpus. The medievalist primary and secondary literature is added chapter by chapter. Perplexity Deep Research is used for the objection-stress-test job on each chapter draft. Nothing is autonomous; every commit is reviewed.

The book that emerges is the one this outline describes.